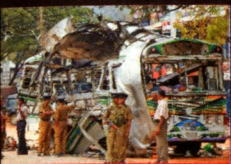


The options available to the LTTE chief

SPREADING TERROR



18 DEAD, 51 INJURED
DAMBULLA, FEB 2 '08



12 DEAD, 90 INJURED
COLOMBO, FEB 3 '08

By striking civilian targets LTTE hopes to stretch internal security forces and push the international community to intervene.



SUCCESSION PLAN

Son Charles Anthony (left, in late teens now) is being groomed and wife Mathivathany could play regent

Prabhakaran sleepless nights, since he has to constantly change his hideouts. The Sri Lankan intelligence believes that there is no clear line of succession if Prabhakaran is killed or incapacitated in an attack. Says Fonseka, "When a ship is sinking, there is no succession line." Pottu Amman, Prabhakaran's intelligence chief and the man who masterminded Rajiv Gandhi's assassination, is the closest to him and controls access to the LTTE chief. It was apparently a battle for supremacy between Amman and Karuna, which saw the latter leave the outfit in a huff. Of late, there has been talk of Prabhakaran passing the mantle to son Charles Anthony, but Fonseka dismisses him as "fat, lazy and incapable of taking over LTTE". Other reports say he is a computer geek and his father is using him to boost LTTE's communications via the Internet. Colonel (retd) G. Hariharan, an Indian military expert, says that after Prabhakaran, Afghan-style warlordism may arise, with LTTE fragmenting.

Already, the Tigers are showing

signs of desperation. They have unleashed a wave of attacks on civilian targets in a bid to take the pressure off them in the battle for Wanni. On the eve of the Independence Day celebrations on February 4, they penetrated the tight Sri Lankan security. A suicide blast at the Fort Railway Station saw 12 people, including seven children, being killed. A bomb had also been planted close to the President's Temple Trees office and only luck prevented what would have been an embarrassing blast for the Government.

LTTE's plan to strike in different towns and not in Colombo alone is intended to stretch the Sri Lankan internal security forces and get them to divert some of the army units from the battle for the north. The Tigers also want to trigger ethnic riots and get the international

community to pressure the Government into ending the offensive. The other option is to maintain status quo in the north, where the battle rages, and to tire the people and the Government. Already, inflation is running at over 20 per cent, and the cost of a loaf of bread has gone up from Rs 15 to Rs 35. If LTTE ensures a stalemate in the war, peoples' patience for the Government may wear thin.

Meanwhile, President Rajapakse has to answer to the international community, including India. He has been told firmly that there is no military solution to the ethnic problem and that peace could return only if his Government came up with a credible devolution package for the Tamils. So Rajapakse hustled the All Party Representative Committee (APRC), which he had appointed to look into the question of devolution, into submitting an interim report. APRC had recommended the implementation of the 13th Amendment brought in by the Indo-Sri Lankan Accord in 1987, which

had advised the setting up of Provincial Councils with powers to run matters related to police, education, health and infrastructure. Very little was done by successive governments to implement its recommendations. Now, the President promises to implement it in toto "as the first step" and has promised to consider any more demands that APRC may make (*see interview*). Meanwhile he has deployed brother Basil Rajapakse to go full speed in developing the east and forming its Provincial Council by March.

This has calmed the international community that has tacitly allowed Rajapakse to continue the war. But there are growing complaints from the West about human rights violations and media censorship. Internal resistance is also growing. Ranil Wickremesinghe, leader of the Opposition and the architect of CFA, does not share the Government's optimism about the war. Nor is he enamoured by the devolution package being promised to the Tamils. Wickremesinghe told INDIA TODAY: "Apart from antagonising the international community by abrogating CFA, the Government still has not come up with a credible devolution plan for the Tamils." Tamil factions, too, are critical. S. Adaikkalanathan, MP and leader of the Tamil Eelam Liberation Organisation, says, "Unable to lay new eggs, the President is duping the Tamils, promising to hatch an egg that has rotted for 60 years."

By staking his prestige on winning against LTTE, or "putting all his eggs in the war basket", as a diplomat describes it, Rajapakse has narrowed his options considerably. The Tigers may be down, but they are certainly not out. And given their past history, there is every possibility that they may bounce back and succeed in bogging down the Sri Lankan Army in a debilitating stalemate. A terror strike on an important leader could also send the President's calculations awry. People's discontent over prices may boil over before the one year the President has asked for is over. Rajapakse has embarked on a dangerous game of brinkmanship. If he succeeds in bagging Prabhakaran, he is certain to win the next elections and continue his reign. If he fails, well, the dustbin of history is never short of space. ■